

Chapter 4

Locative phrases as arguments or adjuncts: Existential and locative sentences in Greek

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This chapter investigates the status of the locative constituent in Greek locative and existential sentences. Given that several types of sentences qualify as locatives and existentials in the language, this study offers a window into the syntax exploited for these two functions. Specifically, it shows that the locative function requires a structure in which the locative constituent is part of the main predication. In contrast, the existential one is achieved via the same structure with an additional change in the word order or via a second structure in which the locative merges as an adjunct. In this sense, this chapter suggests that the syntax behind locatives and existentials may be unified, but not necessarily.

1 Introduction

1.1 Setting the scene

This chapter focuses on several types of locational sentences, i.e., sentences that relate entities to locations, and examines the syntactic properties of the locative phrase, which is a common constituent contained in them. Drawing on evidence from Greek (Indo-European, [mode1248]), this line of research leads us to assume that there is variation in the syntactic structures behind locational sentences. In particular, this chapter shows that their structure, i.e., their syntax, and their pragmatic function, i.e., their use in the discourse, are strongly but not exclusively dependent on each other. To argue for it, I focus on two types of loca-



tional sentences, namely locative and existential ones. After defining what types of sentences fall into each category, their syntax is brought into scrutiny.

To begin with, it must be noted that the terminology surrounding locative and existential sentences is highly controversial, primarily due to the vast literature on these topics. Identifying the commonalities between structures across languages and labeling them accordingly has proven particularly challenging. Furthermore, different perspectives endorsed by the researchers have led to various subcategorizations and definitions (see Haspelmath (2021, 2025a, 2025b)).

Even though several proposals have been made in the literature, adopting function-based definitions for these labels is optimal because, among other reasons, they create a more useful and insightful dataset.¹ By defining locatives and existentials in terms of their pragmatic function, researchers can investigate a range of patterns used for the same purpose. Hence, they can investigate structural similarities and differences among the sentences falling under a single category or between the groups of sentences subsumed under each label.

For present purposes, I adopt Haspelmath's (2025a) distinction between locatives and existentials for whom locative sentences (e.g., in (1)) qualify as predicational sentences in the sense that they include a locative predication with a definite subject. Specifically, the author uses the label 'predlocative constructions' for sentences like the ones presented in (1) and defines them as "a clause construction in which a **definite** (emphasis mine) subject argument is said to be located in a place expressed by a locative phrase".

He also proposes calling the subject/located element the *locatum* (or, more specifically, the *predlocatum*).

- (1) a. *The cat is on the piano.*

¹See Croft (2022) for a similar view. A popular alternative is to define existentials, in particular, in terms of their specialized properties in their surface forms (see Kuno 1971, Milsark 1974, McNally 1997, 2011, Moro 1997, 2006, Bentley et al. 2015, among others). For instance, McNally (2011: 1829) defines existentials as "specialized or non-canonical constructions which express a proposition about the existence or the presence of someone or something". However, I will not adopt this type of definition due to an observation made later by McNally herself, in McNally (2016), where she explains that since 'canonical' is different across languages, 'non-canonical' varies significantly, too. Thus, capturing what is deviant at a cross-linguistic level is not easy. Further, adopting this definition would exclude sentences including *be* or *exist* because, morphologically, they are canonical. Only sentences with expletives, peculiar morphological marking, or atypical word order would qualify as existentials. This would significantly restrict the dataset from which generalizations would be drawn and thus question the validity of these generalizations.

- b. Russian (Indo-European, [russ1263]; Partee & Borschev 2004: 212)
Doktor by-l v gorod-e.
 doctor be-PST.M.SG in town-LOC.SG
 ‘The doctor was in town.’

The specification that predlocative constructions involve a definite locatum is crucial because this characteristic distinguishes them from existential sentences, as the ones presented in (2).

- (2) a. *There is a cat on the piano.*
 b. Russian (Partee & Borschev 2004: 212)
V gorod-e by-l doktor.
 in town-LOC.SG be-PST.M.SG doctor
 ‘There was a doctor in town.’

Likewise, an *existential clause construction* is “a clause in which an indefinite nominal phrase (the *existent*) is said to be in some location” according to Haspel-math (2025a). For the rest of this paper, I will use the term *locative* for predlocative constructions and *existential* for existential clause constructions.

Several researchers investigating these types of sentences have observed an affinity between them. This affinity derives from the fact that locative and existential sentences describe a locative relationship, i.e., a relationship between a locatum/existent, e.g., *a cat* or *a doctor*, and a location, e.g., *a piano* or *a town*, in the sentences above. To use Borschev & Partee’s (1998) formalization, they both express a BE (THING, LOC) proposition where BE represents the locative relationship, THING stands for the movable part of this relationship (locatum/existent), and LOC represents the stable point, the location in which this part appears. Creisels (2014, 2019) and Kampanarou (2023) treat this two-part locative relationship as a Figure-Ground relationship by adopting Talmy’s (1975) distinction between Figures and Grounds.² Regardless of the terminology, these sentences are also truth-conditionally the same since they are true on the same conditions, i.e., when a cat appears on a piano for (1a, 2a) or when a doctor appears in town for (1b, 2b).

A question that has been posed several times in the literature is whether this affinity derives from a unified syntax. In other words, do the locatum/existent and the location have the same syntactic status in both types of sentences?

²Talmy (1975: 419) defines the Figure as “a moving or conceptually movable point whose path or site is conceived as a variable, the particular value of which is the salient issue”. In contrast, the Ground is “a reference point, having a stationary setting within a reference-frame, with respect to which the Figure’s path or site receives characterization”.

Both answers have been given in the literature. On the one hand, many researchers supporting transformational approaches have posited that the syntax behind locatives and existentials is unified (Lyons 1967; Kuno 1971; Milsark 1974; Stowell 1978; Safir 1987; Hoekstra & Mulder 1990; Freeze 1992; Kayne 1993; Sag & Pollard 1994; Kempchinsky 1996; Moro 1997, 2006; Abdoulaye 2006; den Dikken 2006; Peeters et al. 2006, among others). On the other hand, a second strand of the literature has proposed that each sentence type has its own underlying structure. Each structure may have similarities with another structure, but this is not necessary (Barwise & Cooper 1981; Williams 1984; Chung 1987; McNally 1997; Hazout 2004; Francez 2007, 2009; McCloskey 2014; Myler 2018, among others).

In this chapter, I present novel evidence from Greek suggesting that both strands of analysis have a grain of truth. Specifically, I show that the locative function stems from one single syntactic structure. In existentials, the existential function is achieved via distinct structures. In particular, the structure assumed for existentials is either identical or similar to the structure posited for locatives. To argue for this, I focus on the properties and the behavior of the locative constituent, which appears in both types of sentences.

1.2 Greek locatives and existentials

To give some background, according to the above definitions, Greek has two types of locative sentences. The first one typically has a definite noun phrase preceding the verb *ime* ‘be’ and a locative constituent (a prepositional phrase (PP) or adverb) following it. The verb fully agrees (in person and number) with the DP subject (3).³

- (3) a. *I yata ine sto pjano.*
DEF.NOM cat.NOM be.3SG on.DEF.ACC piano.ACC
‘The cat is on the piano.’
b. *Ta fruta ine sto trapezi.*
DEF.PL.NOM fruit.PL.NOM be.3PL on.DEF.ACC table.ACC
‘The fruits are on the table.’

The second type of locative sentence has the same surface order and agreement pattern but uses the non-active version of the verb *vrisko* ‘find’, namely *vriskome* ‘be found’ instead of *ime* ‘be’ (4).

³All data are drawn on Kampanarou (2023) and constitute naturally-occurring sentences that have been judged by approximately 30 speakers of Greek. Note, also, that the typical agreement pattern in *ime*-sentences is not readily clear because of morphological syncretism: the form *ine* is used for the third person singular and the third person plural.

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- (4) a. *O Petros vriskete sto spiti.*
 DEF.NOM Peter.NOM be.found.3SG at.DEF.ACC house.ACC
 ‘Peter is at home.’
- b. *Ta koritsja vriskode stin Kriti.*
 DEF.PL.NOM girl.PL.NOM be.found.3PL in.DEF.ACC Kriti.ACC
 ‘The girls are in Crete.’

Although different existent-location pairs are chosen to illustrate each sentence type, the two verbal items are interchangeable in all contexts above.

On the other hand, there are three types of existentials in Greek: a HAVE-based one, a BE-based one, and an EXIST-based one. In all these sentences, the verbal item typically surfaces in sentence-initial position, the existent follows it, and the locative constituent appears sentence-finally. In HAVE-sentences based on *exi* ‘have’ (5), the existent is marked with accusative case, and the verb appears invariant marked for third-person singular (see Kampanarou 2021, 2023 for more details). This pattern is also familiar in Romance languages (Bentley et al. 2015: 141; Cruschina 2015: 38).

- (5) a. *Exi ena skilo stin peðiki xara.*
 have.3SG INDF.ACC dog.ACC at.DEF.ACC playground.ACC
 ‘There is a dog in the playground.’
- b. *Exi kati skilus stin peðiki xara.*
 have.3SG some dog.PL.ACC at.DEF.ACC playground.ACC
 ‘There are some dogs in the playground.’

In contrast, BE- and EXIST-existentials based on *ime* ‘be’ and *iparxo* ‘exist’ (6, 7), respectively, exhibit the typical agreement pattern of intransitive verbs in Greek.⁴

- (6) a. *Ine ena peði sti mesi tu jipeðu.*
 be.3SG INDF.NOM kid.NOM in.DEF.ACC middle.DEF.ACC DEF.GEN
 field.GEN
 ‘There is a child in the middle of the (football) field.’

⁴Note that in this paper, I describe the distribution of *ime*-existentials based on the judgments of most Modern Greek speakers. In Kampanarou (2023), I separate a smaller group of Modern Greek speakers who accept a second type of *ime*-existentials plausibly due to a specific dialectal background since this group consists of speakers from southern parts of Greece.

- b. *Ine kati peđja sti mesi tu jipeđu.*
 be.3PL some kid.PL.NOM in.DEF.ACC middle.DEF.ACC DEF.GEN field.GEN
 ‘There are some children in the middle of the (football) field.’
- (7) a. *Iparxi kabosos kafes sto dulapi.*
 exist.3SG plenty.of.NOM coffee.NOM in.DEF.ACC cupboard.ACC
 ‘There is plenty of coffee in the cupboard.’
- b. *Iparxun kabosi kafeðes sto dulapi.*
 exist.3PL plenty.of.PL.NOM coffee.PL.NOM in.DEF.ACC cupboard.ACC
 ‘There are plenty of (types of) coffees in the cupboard.’

Again, even though each set of examples includes a different existent-location pair, the three verbal items are interchangeable in all the above cases.

The verb *iparxo* ‘exist’ can also be used for the so-called “hyparctic” clauses or clauses of ontological existence that establish the existence of a kind (8). However, it has a more extensive use than its English or Romance counterparts since it also appears in the locational *iparxo*-existentials displayed above.

- (8) a. *Den ksero an iparxi theos.*
 NEG know.1SG if exist.3SG God.NOM
 ‘I do not know if God exists.’
- b. *I paniða ðen iparxi xoris ti xloriða.*
 DEF.NOM fauna.NOM NEG exist.3SG without DEF.ACC flora.ACC
 ‘Fauna does not exist without flora.’

In this article, I will focus on the locative constituent alone, i.e., the locative PP or adverb contained in locatives and existentials, to investigate whether its syntactic status is uniform across the board. Specifically, I will show that this item is an argument in BE-FOUND-locatives (based on *vriskome*), BE-locatives and BE-existentials (both based on *ime*), whereas it is an adjunct in HAVE-existentials (based on *exi*) and EXIST-existentials (based on *iparxo*). This will constitute sufficient evidence for the assumption that existentials do not have the same underlying structure as locatives. To argue for this, I will investigate the behavior of this item concerning (a) its optionality or obligatoriness in being overt, (b) its ability to drop its preposition, (c) its ability to act as a stage topic, (d) its scopal behavior with respect to the adverbial *again*, (e) the scopal behavior of quantifiers contained in it, and (f) its binding properties. Each criterion is discussed in §2.

2 Investigating the behavior of the locative constituent

2.1 Optionality in its overt realization

The difference in the obligatoriness of being overt is a first property that separates two groups of sentences. First, witness that the locative constituent cannot be omitted under any circumstances in *vriskome*-locatives (9a), *ime*-locatives (9b), and *ime*-existentials (9c).

- (9) a. *Ta vivlia vriskode *(sto trapezi / eđo).*
 DEF.PL.NOM book.PL.NOM be.found.3PL on.DEF.ACC table.ACC here
 ‘The books are *(on the table/here).’
- b. *Ta vivlia ine *(sto trapezi / eđo).*
 DEF.PL.NOM book.PL.NOM be.3PL on.DEF.ACC table.ACC here
 ‘The books are *(on the table/here).’
- c. *Ine kati vivlia *(sto trapezi / eđo).*
 be.3PL some book.PL.NOM on.DEF.ACC table.ACC here
 ‘There are some books (on the table/here).’

In contrast, the locative constituent can be omitted in *exi*- and *iparxo*-existentials like in (10).

- (10) *Exi / Iparxun kati vivlia ([sto trapezi] / [eđo]).*
 have.3SG exist.3PL some book.PL.NOM on.DEF.ACC table.ACC here
 ‘There are some books (on the table/here).’

Notably, the locative constituent can be omitted only if easily retrieved through context or shared or common knowledge. This means that it is semantically present even if it is not phonetically overt. That is, a location is always implied.

Moreover, omitting the overt locative PP or adverb does not make the sentences hyparctic. The crucial difference between hyparctic sentences, e.g. (8), and existentials with an omitted locative constituent is that the omitted locative in hyparctic sentences is not contextually determined. It is a vague spatiotemporal constituent that has more or less the meaning “in the universe, on the planet”. This contrasts with existentials, where the omitted locative may have several denotations depending on the discourse.

Nonetheless, the locative constituent’s ability to be omitted in some existentials is a property indicative of adjuncts.

2.2 P(reposition)-drop

According to Gehrke & Lekakou (2013), who investigate PPs in independent contexts, P(reposition)-drop is only available when PPs including the preposition *se* (which is conflated with the definite determiner) are arguments. This occurs with verbs of directed motion and verbs of location. Adjunct PPs cannot drop their prepositional head, at least in most cases (see also Ioannidou & den Dikken 2009, Terzi 2010, Kouneli 2014, Sifaki 2020).

The researchers show this contrast based on the following examples. In (11a), the complex P *sto*, which comprises *se* and the definite determiner *to*, can be dropped as the PP is an argument of the verbs *ftano* ‘arrive’ and *epistrefo* ‘return’. In contrast, PPs that are adjunct modifiers cannot drop their preposition (11b).

- (11) a. *Ftano* / *Epistrefo* / *Ime* (*sto*) *panepistimio*.
 arrive.1SG return.1SG be.1SG at.DEF.ACC university.ACC
 ‘I am arriving at/I am coming back to/I am at the university.’
 b. *Perpatisa* / *Xorepsa* *(*sto*) *jimnastirio* /
 walk.PST.PFV.1SG dance.PST.PFV.1SG at.DEF.ACC gym.ACC
sxolio / *yrafio* / *eklisia*.
 school.ACC office.ACC church.ACC
 intended: ‘I walked/danced at the gym/school/office/church.’

To employ this as a diagnostic, it is predicted that P-drop will be permitted with non-adjunct PPs. In the cases under discussion, P-drop becomes available only in *vriskome*- and *ime*-sentences (12).⁵

- (12) a. *Ta* *peđja* *vriskode* / *ine* (*sto*) *sxolio* /
 DEF.PL.NOM kid.PL.NOM be.found.3PL be.3PL at.DEF.ACC school.ACC
jimnastirio / *yrafio*.
 gym.ACC office.ACC
 ‘The kids are at the school/gym/office.’
 b. *Ine* *pola* *peđja* (*sto*) *sxolio* / *jimnastirio* /
 be.3PL many kid.PL.NOM at.DEF.ACC school.ACC gym.ACC
yrafio *simera*.
 office.ACC today
 ‘There are many kids at the school/gym/office today.’

⁵I have left aside examples including *spiti* ‘home’ since Terzi (2010) shows that this nominal behaves exceptionally, as is the case cross-linguistically, e.g., with English *home*, German *nachhause* / *zuhause*, Russian *doma* / *domoj*.

Exi- and *iparxo*-sentences do not allow the omission of the preposition heading the locative PP (13).

- (13) *Exi* / *Iparxun* *peđja* *(*sto*) *sxolio* / *jimnastirio* /
 have.3SG exist.3PL kid.PL.NOM/ACC at.DEF.ACC school.ACC gym.ACC
yrafio *simera*.
 office.ACC today
 intended: ‘There are kids at the school/gym/office today.’

Therefore, if we consider P-drop a diagnostic for non-adjuncts, we can argue that the PP is not an adjunct in *vriskome*- and *ime*-locatives and *ime*-existentials. In contrast, it is an adjunct in *exi*- and *iparxo*-sentences.

2.3 Ability to act as stage topics

Building on Cohen & Erteschik-Shir (2002) and Alexiadou (2009), it is expected that non-adjunct locative constituents will act as stage topics (i.e., as the items that indicate the spatiotemporal parameters of the sentence, the here-and-now of the discourse) contra locative adjuncts. Although the contrast is not very sharp, the speakers’ judgments point in the expected direction. The locative PP can act as a stage-topic in locative sentences independent of the verbal item.

- (14) a. *Oso ja to parti, ta peđja vriskode* /
 as for DEF.ACC party.ACC DEF.PL.NOM kid.PL.NOM be.found.3PL
ine akoma eki.
 be.3PL still there
 ‘As for the party, the kids are still there.’
 b. *Oso ja to paljo spiti, ta epipla*
 as for DEF.ACC old.ACC house.ACC DEF.PL.NOM furniture.PL.NOM
vriskode / ine akoma eki.
 be.found.3PL be.3PL still there
 ‘As for the old house, the furniture is still there.’

It does so in *ime*-existentials, too, as presented in (15).

- (15) a. *Oso ja to parti, ine pola peđja akoma eki*.
 as for DEF.ACC party.ACC be.3PL many kid.PL.NOM still there
 ‘As for the party, there are many kids still there.’

- b. (?) *Oso ja to paljo spiti, ine pola epipla*
as for DEF.ACC old.ACC house.ACC be.3PL many furniture.PL.NOM
akoma eki.
still there
‘As for the old house, there is much furniture still there.’

Conversely, the PP in existential sentences with *exi* and *iparxo* cannot act as a stage topic, at least not as easily as in the cases above, cf. (16).

- (16) a. ?? *Oso ja to parti, exi / iparxun pola*
as for DEF.ACC party.ACC have.3PL exist.3PL many
peđja akoma eki.
kid.PL.ACC/NOM still there
intended: ‘As for the party, there are many kids still there.’
- b. ?? *Oso ja to paljo spiti, exi / iparxun pola*
as for DEF.ACC old.ACC house.ACC have.3SG exist.3PL many
epipla akoma eki.
furniture.PL.ACC/NOM still there
intended: ‘As for the old house, there is much furniture still there.’

Therefore, this diagnostic indicates that the locative constituent is an adjunct only in *exi*- and *iparxo*-existentials.

2.4 Scopal behavior of *again*

Another piece of evidence is drawn on the *again*-distribution, which, when used as a diagnostic, shows that the PP in *exi*- and *iparxo*-sentences behaves as an adjunct because it can be left outside the adverb’s scope and, hence, the main predication. Although this test has been used for identifying complex event structure by McCawley (1968, 1971), Dowty (1979), and von Stechow (1996), it is not the use it will receive in this case since the constructions we are investigating are arguably mono-eventive.

The adverb distribution is used as a diagnostic for severing the PP from the predicative layer, i.e., from the constituent where a Figure-Ground relationship is construed. Specifically, it predicts that if the PP can remain outside the scope of the adverb alone, then the PP is not part of the main predication. The examples below show that the adverb leaves the PP outside its scope and scopes over the NP (and the verb, as is always the case) only in *exi*- and *iparxo*-sentences (20) and not in *vriskome*- (17) or *ime*-sentences (18, 19).

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In detail, witness that the locative sentence in (17b) can only mean that the toys are again in Peter's room. This is evidenced by the fact that the location cannot be negated (*ala oxi* 'but not' is unacceptable). This means that *ksana* 'again' takes scope over the nominal and the locative PP.

- (17) a. *Xtes ta pexniđja vriskodan sto*
 yesterday DEF.PL.NOM toy.PL.NOM be.found.PST.3PL in.DEF.ACC
đomatio tu Petru.
 room.ACC DEF.GEN Peter.GEN
 'Yesterday, the toys were in Peter's room.'
- b. *Simera ta pexniđja vriskode ksana (*ala oxi)*
 today DEF.PL.NOM toy.PL.NOM be.found.3PL again but not
sto đomatio tu Petru.
 in.DEF.ACC room.ACC DEF.GEN Peter.GEN
 'Today, the toys are again (*but not) in Peter's room.'

The same is true for *ime*-locatives.

- (18) a. *Xtes ta pexniđja itan sto đomatio*
 yesterday DEF.PL.NOM toy.PL.NOM be.PST.3PL in.DEF.ACC room.ACC
tu Petru.
 DEF.GEN Peter.GEN
 'Yesterday, the toys were in Peter's room.'
- b. *Simera ta pexniđja ine ksana (*ala oxi) sto*
 today DEF.PL.NOM toy.PL.NOM be.3PL again but not in.DEF.ACC
đomatio tu Petru.
 room.ACC DEF.GEN Peter.GEN
 'Today, the toys are again (*but not) in Peter's room.'

In *ime*-existentials, too, the locative PP cannot remain outside the scope of again alone. The adverb takes scope over the NP-PP complex.

- (19) a. *Xtes itan kati pexniđja sto đomatio tu*
 yesterday be.PST.3PL some toy.PL.NOM in.DEF.ACC room.ACC DEF.GEN
Petru.
 Peter.GEN
 'Yesterday, there were some toys in Peter's room.'

- b. *Simera ine ksana kati pexniđja (*ala oxi) sto đomatio*
 today be.3PL again some toy.PL.NOM but not in.DEF.ACC room.ACC
tu Petru.
 DEF.GEN Peter.GEN
 ‘Today, there are again some toys (*but not) in Peter’s room.’

Unlike the above, *exi-* and *iparxo-*existentials (20b) have a reading in which the locative PP is left outside the scope of *ksana* ‘again’. The fact that the PP can be negated suggests that only the NP is within the adverb’s scope (along with the verb).

- (20) a. *Xtes ixē / ipirxan kati pexniđja*
 yesterday have.PST.3SG exist.PST.3PL some toy.PL.ACC/NOM
sto đomatio tu Petru.
 in.DEF.ACC room.ACC DEF.GEN Peter.GEN
 ‘Yesterday, there were some toys in Peter’s room.’
 b. *Simera exi / iparxun ksana kati pexniđja (ala oxi)*
 today have.3SG exist.3PL again some toy.PL.ACC/NOM but not
sto đomatio tu Petru.
 in.DEF.ACC room.ACC DEF.GEN Peter.GEN
 ‘Today, there are again some toys but not in Peter’s room.’

The fact that the adverb can take scope only over the NP in the latter two cases indicates that the NP and the PP do not form a single constituent before the insertion of *ksana* ‘again’. In other words, only the NP is part of the predication brought at least by the verb (if not by a head projected lower). If the PP stays outside the main predication in *exi-* and *iparxo-*existential sentences, the assumption that it merges as an adjunct is the only possible explanation.

To sum up, the diagnostics presented so far suggest that the NP and the PP are part of the same constituent before the insertion of the verb in locatives and *ime-*existentials. In contrast, they do not form a single constituent, at least by the time the verb is inserted in the structure of *exi-* and *iparxo-*existentials. For present purposes, I assume that this constituent is the predication layer (*Pred*), i.e., the layer in which a Figure-Ground relationship is typically construed. In the former case (21a), the predication layer contains both the Figure (NP) and the Ground (PP). In the latter case, (21b), the same layer contains only the Figure (NP). The Ground is introduced later as an adjunct.

- (21) a. [_{VP} v *ime/vriskome* [_{Pred} NP PP]]
 b. [_{VP} [_{VP} v *exi/iparxo* [_{Pred} NP]] PP]

The rest of this chapter corroborates this conclusion and goes one step further as it attempts to pin down the hierarchy between the two constituents, i.e., whether the PP is inserted before the NP or vice versa. If this is conceived of in terms of a syntactic-tree representation, inserting the PP before the NP means that the former constituent is lower than the latter (NP»PP). Conversely, the insertion of the PP after the NP suggests that the former is higher than the latter (PP»NP) (see more in §2.7).

2.5 Quantifier-scope readings

The available quantifier-scope readings, as presented below, provide support for the assumption that the overt locative constituent in *exi*- and *iparxo*-existentials is severed from the main predication, i.e., it is an adjunct, and adjoins to a position hierarchically higher than the existent. To illustrate this, I consider the distribution in (22) and (23).

- (22) a. *Kapjo loyotexniko vivlio vriskete se kaθe taksi.*
 some literary book.NOM be.found.3SG in each classroom.ACC
 ‘A literary book is in every classroom.’ ($\exists > \forall$, $\forall > \exists$)
- b. *Kapjo loyotexniko vivlio ine se kaθe taksi.*
 some literary book.NOM be.3SG in each classroom.ACC
 ‘A literary book is in every classroom.’ ($\exists > \forall$, $\forall > \exists$)
- c. *Ine kapjo loyotexniko vivlio se kaθe taksi.*
 be.3SG some literary book.NOM in each classroom.ACC
 ‘There is a literary book in every classroom.’ ($\exists > \forall$, $\forall > \exists$)

Keep in mind that when the interpretation reached is that of the surface order ($\exists > \forall$), the sentences mean that the same book (i.e., a copy of the same literary book) appears in every classroom. In contrast, under the inverse scope reading ($\forall > \exists$), there is a copy of a different literary book in every classroom. Note that getting the reading according to which the phrase *kapjo loyotexniko vivlio* ‘some literary book’ refers to the copy of one book is not easily accessible for a couple of my informants, yet for those that it is, the judgments point towards a distinction.

As presented above, *vriskome*- and *ime*-sentences allow both scope readings. Building on assumptions made for ditransitives (see den Dikken 1995, Harley 1995, 2002, Pesetsky 1995, Anagnostopoulou 2003), this suggests that the NP and the PP are contained in the same predication layer and the hierarchy between the constituents is depicted in the surface form: the NP is higher than the PP. In contrast, the existential sentences in (23) do not receive the reading according to

which the same copy appears in every classroom. They are mostly, if not solely, interpreted as conveying that each classroom has a different literary book.

- (23) *Exi / Iparxi kapjo loyotexniko vivlio se kaθe taksi.*
 have.3SG exist.3SG some literary book.ACC/NOM in each
 classroom.ACC
 ‘There is a literary book in every classroom.’ (* / ?? $\exists > \forall, \forall > \exists$)

Interestingly, *exi*- and *iparxo*-existential sentences lack the reading corresponding to the surface word order. According to the authors mentioned above, this means that these constituents are not in the same predication layer. On the other hand, it also shows that the surface word order does not correspond to the structural order of the constituents. In other words, it hints that the locative constituent is introduced in a position higher than the nominal (PP»NP). The following section capitalizes on that.

2.6 Binding properties

As further evidence for the hierarchy between the nominal and the locative constituent, I take into account the binding properties of the latter. Consider that the following sentences are used to describe books written by an author that integrates many traits of his personality and autobiographical information in his books.

First, note that the complex NP *o eaftos mu* constitutes a true anaphor in Greek, exempt from logophoric uses (Anagnostopoulou & Everaert 1999; Angelopoulos et al. 2020). Then, notice that a proper name contained in the locative PP in *vriskome*- and *ime*-locatives (24a) and *ime*-existentials (24b) cannot bind an anaphor contained within the argumental noun phrase. An attempt to let the locative PP bind the anaphor leads to strong ungrammaticality.

- (24) a. * *Ta komatja [tu eaftu tu]_i vriskode / ine sta vivlia [tu Petru]_i.*
 DEF.PL.NOM part.PL.NOM of himself be.found.3PL be.3PL
 in.DEF.PL.ACC book.PL.ACC DEF.GEN Peter.GEN
 intended: ‘The parts of himself are in Peter’s books.’

- b. * *Ine pola komatja [tu eafu tu]_i sta vivlia*
 be.3PL many part.PL.NOM of himself in.DEF.PL.ACC book.PL.ACC
[tu Petru]_i.
 DEF.GEN Peter.GEN
 ‘There are many parts of himself in Peter’s books.’

In contrast, the PP can bind an anaphor contained in the nominal argument in *exi*- and *iparxo*-existentials.

- (25) *Exi / Iparxun pola komatja [tu eafu tu]_i sta*
 have.3SG exist.3PL many part.PL.NOM of himself in.DEF.PL.ACC
vivlia [tu Petru]_i.
 book.PL.ACC DEF.GEN Peter.GEN
 ‘There are many parts of himself in Peter’s books.’

Given that the antecedent binding the anaphor must be in a higher c-commanding position, the above distribution suggests that the surface order of the constituents in *exi*- and *iparxo*-existentials does not correspond to their hierarchical order in the syntax. In other words, the locative PP is in a structurally higher position than the nominal in these two cases (PP»NP).

2.7 Interim summary

Overall, the behavior of these sentences suggests that *vriskome*- and *ime*-locatives and *ime*-existentials are unified, at least regarding the behavior of the locative constituent which appears to act as a non-adjunct. In contrast, *exi*- and *iparxo*-sentences include a locative constituent exhibiting the opposite behavior. Table 1 summarizes the properties of the locative constituent with respect to several diagnostics discussed in the previous sections.

Note that the first four criteria indicate properties typical of adjuncts (✓) or non-adjuncts (✗), whereas the latter two provide evidence for the hierarchy between the locative (PP) and the nominal (NP) constituent.

Roughly represented in a syntactic tree, the findings of §2 are as follows. The structure of *vriskome*-locatives and *ime*-sentences (26) is presented in Figure 1, where *Pred* stands for the predication layer and *vP* for the verbal phrase. If an adverb were to instantiate the locative constituent, it would still occupy the same position as the PP.⁶

⁶To answer a question posed by a reviewer, if the preposition heading the prepositional phrase was dropped, it would be assumed that the P-head of the locative PP is silent, i.e., phonetically not realized.

Table 1: The behavior of the locative constituent

PROPERTY	<i>vriskome</i> -LOC	<i>ime</i> -LOC	<i>ime</i> -EX	<i>exi</i> -EX	<i>iparxo</i> -EX
Omission possible	✗	✗	✗	✓	✓
P-drop possible	✗	✗	✗	✓	✓
Act as stage-topic	✗	✗	✗	✓	✓
Outside the scope of <i>again</i>	✗	✗	✗	✓	✓
Surface quantifier-scope	NP»PP	NP»PP	NP»PP	PP»NP	PP»NP
PPs bind anaphors in NPs	NP»PP	NP»PP	NP»PP	PP»NP	PP»NP

- (26) a. *Ta vivlia vriskode / ine sto trapezi.*
 DEF.PL.NOM book.PL.NOM be.found.3PL be.3PL on.DEF.ACC table.ACC
 ‘The books are on the table.’
 b. *Ine kati vivlia sto trapezi.*
 be.3PL some book.PL.NOM on.DEF.ACC table.ACC
 ‘There are books on the table.’

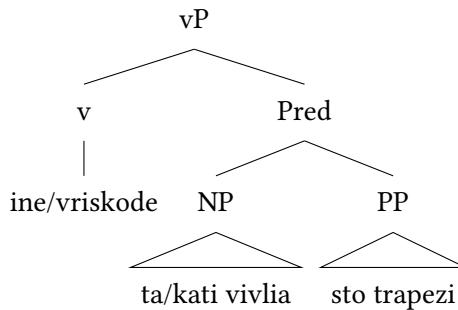


Figure 1: The underlying structure of *vriskome*-locatives and *ime*-sentences

In contrast, the structure of *exi*- and *iparxo*-existentials (27) is shown in Figure 2. Note that following traditional assumptions, I hold that the adjunct rewrites the verbal phrase (vP). Again, if an adverb appeared instead of the PP the adjunction process would stay the same.

- (27) *Exi / Iparxun kati vivlia sto trapezi / eđo.*
 have.3SG exist.3PL many book.PL.NOM/ACC on.DEF.ACC table.ACC here
 ‘There are some books on the table/here.’

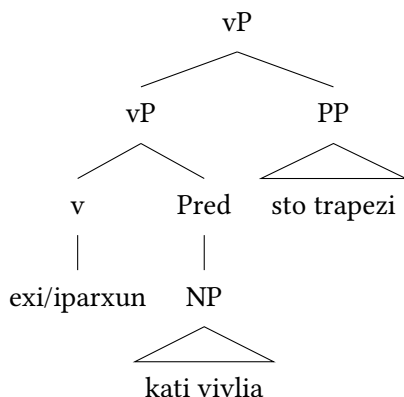


Figure 2: The underlying structure of *exi*- and *iparxo*-existentials

The following section addresses what these conclusions contribute to our understanding of the syntax underneath locative and existential sentences. It also offers a preliminary account for the fact that the sentences under discussion exhibit a variation in the surface word order: in locatives, the NP appears in a pre-verbal position, whereas in existentials, in a post-verbal one.

3 Towards a syntactic analysis

3.1 Tying our conclusions to existing analyses

Although I will refrain from providing a formal syntactic analysis (see Kamparou 2023 for one), I will consider how compatible the findings of this research are with some widespread assumptions about the syntax behind locatives and existentials.

First, we have concluded that the locative constituent in *exi*- and *iparxo*-existentials behaves as an adjunct, i.e., as a modifier. This means that it does not appear as an argument in the structure, and, thus, it must be severed from the main predication. This is in line with McNally (1997) and Francez (2007, 2009), who put forth an adjunct-analysis for the locative constituent in existentials (see also Myler 2018).

Second, the locative constituent is argued to be part of the main predication in the rest of the cases. This conclusion has a two-fold interpretation. On the one hand, this could mean that the locative PP or adverb is the main predicate of the sentence, i.e., the constituent that introduces and construes the Figure-Ground relationship. In that case, the nominal constituent, i.e., the locatum in *ime*- and *vriskome*-locatives or the existent in *ime*-existentials, would constitute the subject of the predicate, i.e., its argument. Further, the verb would be considered semantically vacuous, merging in the structure to “sentencify” the non-verbal predication brought by the locative. In broad terms, in this scenario, the locative constituent builds a Figure-Ground relationship by establishing a Ground that awaits an argument to take over the role of the Figure. This line of thinking is closely related to early assumptions made by Stowell (1978), Chomsky (1981), and Safir (1982), among others.

On the other hand, since the diagnostic of P-drop suggests that the locative constituent in locatives and *ime*-existentials is not only part of the main predication, but an argument, in particular, it could be posited that the verb serves as the predicate. As the main predicate, the verb selects the locative as its argument instantiating the Ground. In this case, the nominal constituent would be the second argument selected by the verb and would instantiate the Figure. This would concur with Milsark (1974), Keenan (1987), Sag & Pollard (1994), and Dalmi (2021), among others.⁷

Even though the specifics of a syntactic analysis are not currently presented, this chapter has shown that the structure of existential sentences does not necessarily reduce to the structure of locatives. It has been demonstrated that the syntax behind the two types of sentences is identical, at least with respect to the status of the overt locative constituent, in the case of *vriskome*- and *ime*-locatives and *ime*-existentials. In contrast, it is not the same if *ime*-sentences and *vriskome*-locatives are compared to *exi*- and *iparxo*-existentials. This confirms that both strands of analyses mentioned in §1.1 have some merit of truth.

Nonetheless, it is essential, that despite their structural affinity, the surface word order of *ime*-locatives and *ime*-existentials is not the same. The following section attempts to provide an explanation for this.

⁷Alternatively, following assumptions, prevalent in the generative tradition, holding that the predication is provided by a covert predication head, e.g., a phonetically null *Pred*-head that is in turn selected by the verb (Moro 1997, McCloskey 2014, Irwin 2018, and Myler 2018, among others), the distribution described in this chapter could be also considered compatible with the hypothesis that the overt locative constituent in locatives and *ime*-existentials is an argument of this head. Kampanarou (2023) offers an analysis in this spirit.

3.2 A note on word order patterns

Even though we posit an identical structure for *ime*-locatives and *ime*-existentials, their surface form differs since the nominal argument that appears pre-verbally in the former case appears post-verbally in the latter case. This is schematically demonstrated in (28).

- (28) a. [Nominative DP]_{LOCATUM} [*ime*] [Locative PP/Adverb]_{LOCATION}
(Locative)
b. [*ime*] [Nominative DP]_{EXISTENT} [Locative PP/Adverb]_{LOCATION}
(Existential)

Interestingly, “manipulating” the word order in order to change the function of the sentence is a common strategy cross-linguistically. However, as pointed out for Gawarbatl (Panova & Liljegren 2025) and several other languages (Cohen & Erteschik-Shir 2002; Beaver et al. 2005; Partee & Borschev 2006; Francez 2007, 2009; Gast & Haas 2011; Cruschina 2012; Bentley 2013; Halevy 2022), changing the word order is not a simple surface scrambling.

According to Partee & Borschev (2004: 217), locatives and existentials differ in their perspectival center, i.e., “the participant chosen as the point of departure for structuring the situation”. The authors claim that in (28a), the proposition, i.e., the Figure-Ground relationship in our terms, is expressed through the Figure’s perspective. In contrast, the same proposition is expressed through the perspective of the Ground in (28b). For the same authors, this variation is depicted on the surface order: the Figure is fronted only in the case of locatives.

A question that has considerably concerned research through the years is whether this shift in perspective is related to the information structure, i.e., the part of syntax where the speaker/addressee’s mental representations of how the information is “packaged” are encoded. Although several assumptions have been made in the literature, particularly with respect to locatives and existentials (see the references above), Kampanarou (2023) shows that the two are co-related yet not directly as the word order is what creates the link between them: information Structure manipulates the word order to determine the topic of the sentence, and this leads to the variation in the perspectives.

In more detail, in the sense of Lambrecht (1994), the topic is primarily a concept independent of linguistic expressions: the topic is the referent whom the situation is about (see also Strawson 1964, Reinhart 1981). More specifically, topics are known referents that function as the anchor for the utterance. For this reason, it is often assumed that topics provide the perspective of the utterance,

i.e., they act as their perspectival centers. Focusing on Greek, Roussou & Tsimpli (2006), Spyropoulos & Revithiadou (2009), and Sifaki (2013) argue that topics in this language are items that are structurally introduced in the vP-layer, broadly speaking, and move to the upper part of the structure, i.e., to information structure.

In the cases under discussion, this is what happens in locative sentences: the nominal constituent is the known referent. Thus, it becomes the topic of the sentence, is fronted, and constitutes its perspectival center. In contrast, the fact that the verbal item surfaces sentence-initially in existentials suggests that neither argument constitutes the topic of the sentence and its perspectival center. The utterance does not have a participant as its anchor point. Nonetheless, it could be assumed that the word order it exhibits suggests that the whole situation is presented from the perspective of the situation itself. Therefore, as for *ime*-sentences, it could be said that despite their structural similarities, their variation in the surface word order is determined later in the derivation, i.e., in their information structure.

In any case, it is essential that word order is tied primarily to the choice of the perspectival center. Whether the two are also dependent on information structure needs further support, although the influential work by Cohen & Erteschik-Shir (2002) and the remarks in Kampanarou (2023: 70–73, 198–201) point towards the postulation that it is.

4 Conclusions

The discussion in this paper has highlighted that to achieve the existential function, the grammar (a) opts for using a structure that is already available for locative sentences or (b) makes use of a structure that is similar but not identical to the one exploited for locatives. Specifically, the Greek data has shown that the locative function is achieved via a single structure, at least in regard to the status of the locative constituent. In this structure, which is assumed for *vriskome*- and *ime*-locatives, the locative constituent is part of the main predication. On the other hand, the existential function is reached via a syntactic structure similar to locatives (this is what happens with *ime*-existentials) or through a different structure where the locative constituent is an adjunct (*exi*- and *iparxo*-existentials).

Overall, the Greek distribution has shown there are several strategies available for achieving the locative and existential functions. It is up to the language to choose which one(s) will be used for each function and whether additional strategies (e.g., manipulating the word order through information structure) may

interfere. This chapter has made an initial contribution regarding this matter. A more detailed investigation of how the rest of the items contained in these sentences behave and, thus, what their status is, will shed more light on the structure lying underneath locatives and existentials.

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